

THE FAMILY ENCLOSURE WITH LDRP ROOM AT COLUMBIA ASIA, KOLKATA (LEFT); THE PLUSH LOBBY OF THE CRADLE AT BANGALORE



It's not just feel-good and orange blossoms, designer birth centres revolve round the idea of LDRP (or Labour-Delivery-Recovery-Post-partum) suites. It's a concept that originated in the US in the 1990s to reduce the need to move around a woman during the four stages of the delivery process and to provide greater privacy. "Since there are no transfers, infection level is minimal," says Dr Anita Soni, consultant obstetrician and gynaecologist at the L.H. Hiranandani Hospital, Mumbai. "The psychological stress of childbirth is also low, as the suites encourage the family to stay with the mother."

Newness, of course, comes at a price. If neighbourhood maternity homes charge about Rs 20,000, birthing suites can cost anything between Rs 45,000 and Rs 2 lakh. On an average, hospitals spend over Rs 20 lakh on a birthing suite. Also, even if you take the basic package, the experience is never plain vanilla gynaecological and paediatric consultation. Long before would-be mothers get admitted, the centres run the parents through antenatal courses, exercise classes, parent and sibling counselling and so on. "Fathers are encouraged to play an active role in the birth of the child," says Dr Amita

Phadnis, director, Oyster and Pearl. Newborns are screened in neonatal intensive care units fitted with baby-warmers, ventilators and other advanced technology. New mothers are cared for too—pelvic-floor exercises to post-partum blues.

The fabulous add-ons—plush wi-fi suites, themed décor, remote-controlled beds that turn into reclining chairs at the time of delivery, concealed equipment that comes out at the touch of a button once labour starts, personalised diet, free-flowing visiting hours, private family enclosures with kitchenette, refrigerator, microwave and television—obviously hike up the bill further. But new-age parents don't seem to mind. "We had taken the Tender Loving Care package at The Nest," says M.P. Ramesh, a Bangalore techie. "The bill came to about Rs 72,000. Most of it came from insurance."

So happy parents are leaving happy. With 120 births a month at The Cradle, Rohit explains the success mantra: "small things go a long way". The Cradle addresses apparent trivia, "Say, when a patient is carried on a stretcher, the glare of ceiling lights creates anxiety. So we put in diffused lighting on the stretcher trail," he says. "Pregnancy is not an illness. It's an occasion to rejoice," adds Dr Ranjana Sharma of La Femme. "The idea is to encourage normal delivery and make it as comfortable as possible." So opt for Gayatri chants to soothe frayed nerves; soak in a jacuzzi to relieve pain; ask for *mithai* and throw a party at the hospital celebration arena. The choice is endless. Feel good while you are at it. ■

AS GOOD AS IT GETS



THE CRADLE, BANGALORE: This outfit offers you luxury car pick-ups, opulent suites fitted with aromatic candles, colour-coordinated washrooms and music of your choice at labour



FORTIS LA FEMME, DELHI: Here you get custom-made tiles with the baby's foot and hand impression or name tiles mounted on a wooden base. The gift shop is worth checking.



THE NEST, BANGALORE: From anti-stretch creams, gowns to antenatal, Lamaze classes, you get it all in their Tender Loving Care privilege package that goes beyond medical tests.



HIRANANDANI HOSPITAL, MUMBAI: Special attraction is the king-size hydrotherapy tub for pain relief during delivery. The suites have family space with a kitchenette, microwave, etc.



COLUMBIA ASIA, KOLKATA: Only of its kind in the east, it has a playpen for siblings of the newborn, apart from the luxurious delivery room that has a family space with a kitchenette.



OYSTER & PEARL, PUNE: Here you get massage parlours, hand-embroidered sheets, a 'celebration arena', cyber café, cord blood banking and complete post-delivery care.



ARTEMIS, GURGAON: From cheery flowers to soothing paintings, choose from different delivery packages such as state-of-the-art economy rooms or megaluxury presidential suites.